

Finding Beneficial Hall

By 1838 Black Metropolis
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On May 17, 1838, Pennsylvania Hall burned to the ground.

Many assumed the hall would serve primarily white abolitionist groups, likely because Quakers funded much of it and its first convention was interracial. However, Pennsylvania Hall was actually designed to meet Black community needs—for schools, lectures, economic groups, philanthropic organizations, beneficial society meetings, and abolitionist gatherings.

When it was destroyed, the community's need for meeting space didn't disappear.

Stephen Smith, a wealthy Methodist minister and abolitionist leader, calculated the demand. The Black community had 15 churches, 21 day schools, 17 sabbath schools, 3 debating societies, 64 beneficial societies, 2 moral reform societies, and 4 temperance societies. These groups held "more than 3000 meetings a year. Literally, 10 meetings a night." The community relied on just six buildings for these gatherings: Benezet Hall, 512 South 7th Street, the Philadelphia Institute at 717 Lombard Street, and the basements of Mother Bethel AME, St. Thomas African Episcopal Church, and Second African Presbyterian Church.

Pennsylvania Hall was meant to be the solution—especially since Black groups often couldn't access white-owned halls. By 1842, four years after the fire, Smith owned two lots on Lombard and 7th and was converting them into a new hall.

Searching for Beneficial Hall

In 1842, Smith's hall was nearly complete with a waiting list of renters. He wrote that he "was obliged to refuse making any further arrangement with them, until the building was finished, having already engaged it for the day time, and four evenings in every week."

On August 1, 1842, a white mob executed a planned arson attack and burned the hall down.

Connecting the Court Case to Smith

After Pennsylvania Hall burned, a law was passed allowing property owners to sue for damages from mob violence. Smith used this law. The 1838 PAS Census noted that "the city must pay for both, according to the new law passed since the burning of Pennsylvania Hall."

A Vermont Religious Observer article from March 14, 1843, finally connected Smith to the court case and the hall.

Location Found

Research by the Philadelphia Historical Commission revealed:

- In 1841, Stephen Smith acquired two lots on the north side of Lombard Street near 7th Street; lots 61 and 62, at addresses 639 and 641 Lombard Street.**
- The lot next to Smith's property was owned by J. Simons, as noted in newspaper reports about the fire.**
- The 1860 Hexamer & Locher insurance map shows a court (Washington Court) west of Smith's lots, matching newspaper descriptions of homes on a court damaged by the fire.**

Smith likely built his five-story hall fronting Washington Court rather than Lombard Street, using both lots to accommodate the larger structure.

- When Harriet Smith died in 1880, the lots were passed to the Home for the Aged and Infirm Colored Persons, an institution Smith founded. A deed mentions the property comprised 5 buildings and lots—matching Smith's will.**

Rebuilding

After the fire, Smith built new homes on the site, visible on 1860 and 1895 maps. Though their later use isn't documented, the location remained central to the Black Metropolis—a hub for halls, schools, underground railroad safe houses, churches, and shelters.

Aftermath

Both Stephen Smith and Second African Presbyterian Church won their court cases. Remarkably, a year after the church

burned, a new one was built. The Black Metropolis continued growing: Lombard Central Presbyterian rose at 8th and Lombard, the Moral Reform Retreat (a shelter for Black women) opened at 7th and Lombard, and by 1851, the Institute of Colored Youth opened with a new building and public library.

Smith's will referred to Beneficial Hall as "my hall" thirty years after it burned—still close, still personal. We can only imagine the deep, unrequited injury that probably never fully healed as he watched both Pennsylvania Hall and then his own Beneficial Hall burn while fire engines stood by doing nothing.

Images

- Stephen Smith contemplates building a new hall after Pennsylvania Hall burns — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_9d259ba83bcc4a508cff554347b01b56~mv2.jpg
- Detail from "A View of the City of Brotherly Love" political cartoon, 1842 — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_02af1efb68a948a8a3a016a898aaae89~mv2.png
- Entry in the Appearance Docket of the Pennsylvania Supreme Court — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_c10acc0e89cd415da56a6f1701c86eb9~mv2.png
- Item Fourth from the Will of Stephen Smith — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_465e375a77c04ab2b2b77c226692a04e~mv2.png
- "The Scene of the Riot" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_e68c5ce6899a40c49f840e59640fbfb8~mv2.png
- Letter to the editor signed by 'Truth' — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_406ee3b60f84400c9663ab29db961e0e~mv2.png
- "The Pennsylvania Hall Burnt" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_ab17857469fc4f24a88f44709bd88a72~mv2.png
- "Indemnification - Riots - Burnt Property" — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_3031fd5faaf64b7a9a3d316ea291bd64~mv2.png
- Deed Sheet, Perry Warren to Stephen Smith — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_79b70407f1da4cd7a5789c45c4e18614~mv2.png
- Visual of two lots on Lombard owned by Stephen Smith — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_745f1f9acc9e4e82877ce40b736cc5ef~mv2.png
- 1860 Hexamer and Lochar map — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_33537a061c304fb3b70da86c1f353f31~mv2.png
- Detail from 1842 mob attack lithograph — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_59980b751b28453993370c7f07ab1138~mv2.png
- Deed Sheet, Esther Price et al to Jas. Simons — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_78faa298b62744bfa034698badc1dcf0~mv2.png
- Visual depicting Jas. Simons lots next to Stephen Smith's — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_41adc18a200b4dc08d04503d2fbf3e99~mv2.png
- Visual depicting court to the west of Smith's lots — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_df99539562474057ad8fcd6697836e8e~mv2.png
- Churches and halls at 7th and Lombard location — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_6c2d79704996411286f5b8e6197272c8~mv2.png
- Second African Presbyterian (Stuart Memorial Hall) — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_d3b6baa0eb694d51b5ffdb35b1a9ea2d~mv2.png
- Stephen Smith portrait — https://static.wixstatic.com/media/af048d_f4b3beba57043608c7b06b17396b0bc~mv2.jpeg

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